East Swindon Development Group

WATER VOLE AND OTTER SUMMARY REPORT

December 2015

FPCR Environment and Design Ltd
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1.0 INTRODUCTION

1.1. This report has been prepared by FPCR Environment and Design Ltd on behalf of a consortium comprising Hallam Land Management Ltd, Taylor Wimpey and Hannick Homes. It follows on from previous FPCR Ecological Reports conducted through the duration of this project, where various ecological surveys have been conducted.

1.2. Evidence of both otters and water voles has been recorded in the wider area during surveys by FPCR in 2006, with otter spraints seen around Acorn bridge located just off the A420 and water vole evidence seen in the north eastern extent of the River Cole off site to the east and on the South Marston Brook to the east of the current site boundary. During the surveys conducted during September 2010, water vole evidence was seen along the River Cole which runs westerly through the site, however field signs were sparse and very isolated. No otter evidence was seen.

2.0 METHODOLOGY

Background

Water Vole and Otter

2.1. Water voles are now fully protected under section 9 of the Wildlife and Countryside Act 1981 (as amended). Otters are fully protected through their inclusion in Schedule 2 of The Conservation (Natural Habitats, &c.) Regulations 1994 (as amended) and under the Wildlife & Countryside Act 1981 (as amended). They are afforded protection under Section 9 parts 4(a) and 4(b).

2.2. Water courses were assessed for their potential as suitable habitat for water voles and otters including the degree of bank side and emergent vegetation, bank shape and angle and size and flow of the water course. Water courses were also examined during June 2015 for physical signs of water voles and otters, Signs searched for included:

- Prints;
- Water vole latrines or otter spraints;
- Holes visible in the banks typical of the species;
- Grazed ‘lawns’ along aquatic margins;
- Feeding stations; and
- Possible otter lying up sites such as sheltered cavities in river side willows.

3.0 RESULTS (REFER TO FIGURE 1)

3.1. This South Marston Brook runs through the site from the north west to east where it joins to the River Cole. The majority of the banks were over shaded by hedgerows and trees which bound a number of arable fields; bank side vegetation was also low in cover. Water levels ranged from 30-60cm in depth and were fast flowing causing a lot of erosion on the soft clay substrate that lines the brook. Some sections of the brook had a stone bed.

3.2. The banks were steep at approximately 70 -90 degrees, which was made up of a mixture of clay and soil, the over hanging root systems helped to support the banks and provided grassy overhangs that would be ideal territory marking locations for water voles. The number of over hanging roots and trunks would also be good locations for otter spraints to be located, however nothing was seen (see photo 1).

3.3. The eastern sections of brook recorded no signs of either otters or water vole, however the fresh abrasions of the banks would suggest that water levels had recently been high, thus this might have washed away any evidence. However the lack of vegetation suggest this brook less suitable for water voles, although the banks do have the potential to be used for burrowing. Over-shading by trees and scrub, which lined the majority of the northern bank increased towards the west and marginal vegetation was lacking as a result.

3.4. A small tributary/ditch extends from the South Marston Stream south towards the A420 this only had a couple of centimetres of water but supported a wide variety of marginal species such as reed sweet grass, common comfrey, greater willowherb and meadow sweet, there were also sections of reedmace and common reed. Water levels decreased closer to the A420. During surveys here no evidence of any water vole or otters were seen.

Photo 1: Typical habitat within the South Marston Brook

Photo 2: Small ditch running from south to north from the A420

3.5. A number of prints, holes and well used runs were observed at and close to the site boundary with Nightingale Wood in the North East. Confirmation that these were made by brown rat *Rattus norvegicus* was noted in the form of droppings.

4.0 DISCUSSION

4.1. Both water vole and otter records are relatively widespread locally and these species have been noted from the River Cole and South Marston Brook to the east and north of the site. They have

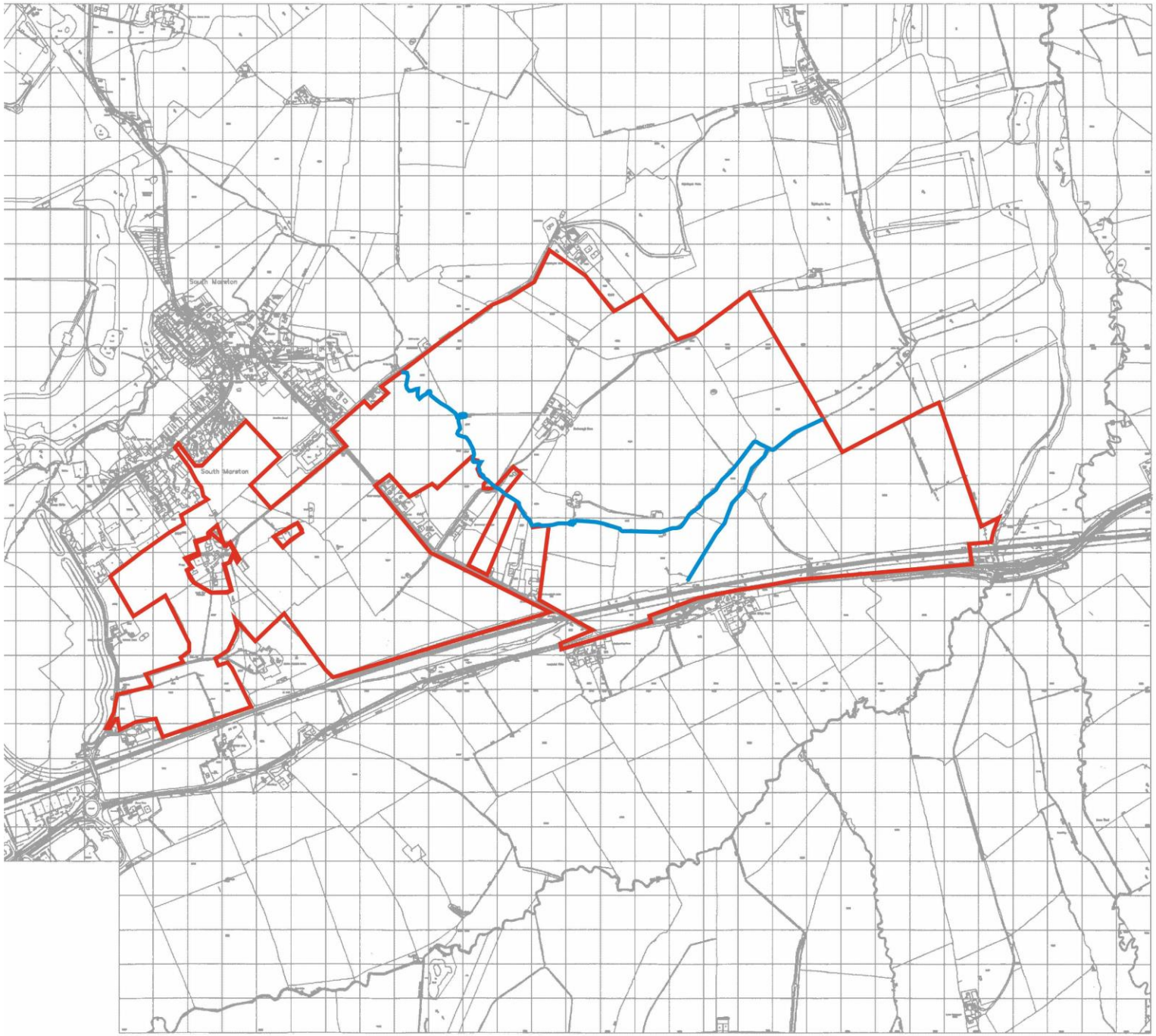
not been recorded within the site during the most recent survey completed in 2015 or recent years.

4.2. As both species can colonise new sites with relative ease and it is recommended that update surveys are completed before undertaking any river engineering works or those associated with the disruption of bank sides. This may include the installation of surface water drainage headwalls, bridges or landscape works, which should ideally avoid occupied habitat.

4.3. Opportunities for habitat enhancement do occur where over-shading by bank side vegetation has inhibited the development of any significant marginal vegetation that could provide cover and foraging habitat.

4.4. No evidence of otters was observed, however, given their potentially large range their occasional use of the site could not be ruled out. However, no places of rest or shelter were identified and it is therefore unlikely that this species represents a constraint.

4.5. Update survey for both are recommended where works are required within 5m (water voles) and 50m (otter) of banks sides.



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Survey Boundary

Watercourse/ditch

Hallam Land Management, Taylor Wimpey & Hannick Homes

Swindon

WATER VOLE AND OTTER SURVEY PLAN

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Figure 1

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